

Chapter 144_1 - Flying Flower Sect

Speaking like this, even if she asked her to climb mountains or dive into seas, it would be difficult to refuse. Ning Fuyi followed her suggestion and wrapped one arm around her shoulders and slipped the other through the crook of her knees, rising in this awkward position.

She initially couldn't stand steady, staggering two steps before the two of them transformed into light and shadow, slipping through the door crack. They quickly returned to the pavilion within Jingshan Palace. Ning Fuyi leaned forward and toppled over - fortunately there was a bed in front of them, though the bed wasn't particularly soft, so Chu Qingqiu ended up sitting down hard on it.

She bit her lip lightly from the pain and reached out to pinch Ning Fuyi, saying in a low voice: "Clumsy hands and feet."

"My apologies." Ning Fuyi wanted to both laugh and felt heartache, so she stepped forward to turn her over. "Where did you hurt yourself? Let me rub it for you..."

Before she could finish speaking, her forehead received a light knock.

"I didn't mean it that way..." Ning Fuyi mumbled while touching her head, then reacted and knelt on the bed, raising her eyebrows: "So what if I did?"

Chu Qingqiu met her gaze, and her body naturally softened. She opened her mouth to tease: "No proper form."

"Then do you not like it?" Ning Fuyi leaned down, trapping her between her arms, her gaze wandering over Chu Qingqiu's increasingly flushed features.

Her gaze seemed to have substance, sweeping over someone like a caress.

Chu Qingqiu secretly gripped her hanging sleeve, hesitated for a moment, then said: "I like it."

"I like every aspect of Yiyi," she said.

Speaking honestly about the love in one's heart is the first step in learning to love someone - this was what Jiang Li had taught her that day when she was drunk.

Perhaps she wouldn't have the chance to learn the rest in the future, but what she had learned, she must put to use.

Ning Fuyi looked at her honest gaze, feeling a touch of sourness in her heart, so she slowly kissed toward her neck, leaving small, rosy marks.

Chu Qingqiu tilted her head following her movements and closed her eyes.

Pleasant tremors quickly enveloped her, soft murmurs turning into words muffled against lips, until finally tears dampened the embroidered silk pillow beneath her.

Smoke from the incense burner in the corner squeezed out through the gaps, intertwining with other wisps of smoke before finally merging into one and disappearing from sight.

Chu Qingqiu's reaction this time was much stronger than the previous times. Halfway through she cried so much it broke Ning Fuyi's heart, so half the time was spent in intimate tenderness, while the other half was entirely used to comfort her.

Ning Fuyi didn't say much - she understood Chu Qingqiu's reluctance.

Her own reluctance was no lighter.

Time passed unknowably. When the incense in the burner had burned out and no longer produced smoke, Ning Fuyi finally collapsed in exhaustion, allowing Chu Qingqiu to lie in her arms as they embraced tenderly.

They lay in silence like this for a while when footsteps came from outside and the door was knocked. A fairy attendant spoke timidly: "Divine Venerable, Sect Master Tang has arrived. Elder Pingyao requests your presence at Cloud Deep Hall."

"What matter?" Chu Qingqiu spoke, her voice having already returned to its usual composure.

"Elder Pingyao did not explain, only saying that the Divine Venerable should go alone."

A complex look flashed through Chu Qingqiu's eyes. She slowly rose, and Ning Fuyi also rose with her movement, reaching out to tie her disheveled sash.

"Could it be news about the Jade Pure Open Cloud Bottle?" Ning Fuyi asked quietly while helping her dress.

Chu Qingqiu shook her head without speaking.

Ning Fuyi didn't use immortal power, carefully arranging her clothing bit by bit. Finally, she draped the moonlight-like cloak over her before saying: "Go then."

"If there are any unexpected developments, you must tell me," Ning Fuyi instructed.

"Alright," Chu Qingqiu replied.

The door opened and closed. Ning Fuyi watched the hem of that person's robes disappear from her sight and suddenly felt the surroundings were excessively quiet - even the sound of dust settling on the eaves could be heard clearly.

So she stood up to arrange her clothing and appearance. She initially wanted to summon Han Ya, but suddenly remembered that Cloud Ascension Mountain had barriers, so she simply moved outside the mountain. When she found herself standing in a patch of greenery, only then did she form an array.

The array formation vanished, and Han Ya's figure appeared before her.

"Demon Lord!" As soon as she appeared, even the wind around them seemed to become noisy. Ning Fuyi pressed her index finger to her lips: "Shh."

Han Ya quickly covered her mouth, her dark eyes darting around.

"Demon Lord, are you asking about the whereabouts of the Jade Pure Open Cloud Bottle?" Han Ya opened her mouth wide and spoke in a whisper. "Our demon cave sisters and brothers have turned the demon realm upside down, but haven't heard half a word about it. The people from Treacherous Fear Hall have also gone to investigate, but most of the news they've reported back is irrelevant."

"I know there's no news," Ning Fuyi said. "This time it's another task."

"Do you know of a place called Cangyun¹ from several hundred years ago? It's said to have been destroyed by the demon race. If this was indeed done by the demon race, we should be able to find out who was responsible."

"Cangyun Kingdom?" Han Ya scratched her head. "Never heard of it."

"Then go back and investigate thoroughly - who did it, why they did it. You must investigate every detail of the matter clearly," Ning Fuyi instructed.

"Rest assured, I, Han Ya, am most reliable in handling affairs!" Han Ya straightened her back and patted her chest, forgetting to even say goodbye as she turned and flew away.

Ning Fuyi nearly got a face full of feathers and silently stepped back to avoid those flying plumes.

Usually when she first entered the demon realm, she hadn't remembered this matter at all, but now seeing Qiu's² suspicious behavior, she always wanted to investigate.

Seeing Han Ya depart, Ning Fuyi waved her sleeve and returned to the mountain gate. As she swept through the air, she happened to see the reflective glazed tiles on top of Zhuguan Pavilion. Feeling nostalgic, she quietly descended.

The path was still that same path, the door still that same door, only the disciples were all listening to the elders' lectures at Xuanliang Garden at this time, so the courtyard was empty, with only the wall full of rose flowers red as fire.

Ning Fuyi pushed open the door and entered. She was immediately greeted by a dog's bark, then a large dog the size of a person leaped out from inside the gate, baring its fangs as it lunged for her throat.

Ning Fuyi was somewhat surprised but not alarmed. She simply stepped lightly to the side and used minimal force to push the large dog away. The dog performed a very strange flip in mid-air, then landed on all fours and charged at her again.

"Ping'an!" Ning Fuyi frowned as she called its name.

After hearing the familiar voice, Ping'an almost instantly changed its expression, whimpering as it landed and nuzzled close to Ning Fuyi with its large, jet-black nose, sniffing vigorously.

This time it finally caught the familiar scent. Its tail, which had been standing straight as a blade, suddenly curved and wagged on its rear end like a blooming flower.

"Woof, woof, woof!" Ping'an bounced excitedly to Ning Fuyi's front, spinning around her frantically.

"Decades without seeing you, and you've grown this big," Ning Fuyi felt deeply moved. She reached down to pet Ping'an's head - it felt like silk warmed by sunlight, smooth and warm.

That little round dog that once only knew how to eat and sleep had now grown so imposing and dignified, with fangs like blades, eyes like swords, and four giant paws that seemed to shake the earth when they hit the ground.

"Truly worthy of being a Jiuying's³ egg," Ning Fuyi smiled as she crouched down, getting her face licked by Ping'an's slobbery tongue.

"Ping'an, you're sneaking around again..." At this moment a delicate shout rang out. A woman carrying a thousand-pound hammer ran out from the house, but when she saw Ning Fuyi, her words stopped abruptly.

Liu Wenzhu's face reddened as she quickly put away the thousand-pound hammer and smiled charmingly: "Yiyi, so it's you who came. I woke up and didn't see Ping'an, thinking it had snuck out again."

Ning Fuyi also smiled, rubbing Ping'an's head before standing up: "I was thinking it had been so long since I'd seen Ping'an, so I came to take a look."

She paused, worry rising in her eyes: "Why does your complexion look so poor?"

Liu Wenzhu touched her cheek upon hearing this, wearily brushing away her hair, her voice as gentle as water: "It's nothing, just those Liu family matters - too many disputes wearing down one's spirit."

Ever since Liu Wenhai died at the hands of the demon race, the Liu family had fallen into a struggle for family headship. Although Liu Wenhai had already left instructions for Liu Wenzhu to succeed as family head, the other clan relatives all refused to acknowledge it - firstly because Liu Wenzhu was a woman, secondly claiming she was young and ignorant. In any case, they found plenty of excuses to obstruct her succession.

Not to mention there were also cousin-brothers and uncle-nephews eyeing the position wanting their share. Liu Wenzhu's days could be imagined.

"Do you want me to help?" Ning Fuyi asked with sympathy.

Liu Wenzhu shook her head, her almond eyes curving into crescents: "It's fine. The Penglai⁴ matter is more urgent now. These are just private disputes - I can deal with them later."

"Besides, perhaps they're right - my abilities are limited, and I'm simply not cut out to be family head," Liu Wenzhu said with feigned lightness.

"How could that be? You..."

"Enough, Yiyi." Liu Wenzhu interrupted her words, bending down to touch Ping'an's head with her fingertips. "I was just about to go to Flying Flower Sect."

"Elder Pingyao said that war could break out at any moment. When people encounter ghost fire they will surely perish, so we need Flying Flower Sect's mechanism arts to control puppets in order to reduce casualties. So I need to go borrow some puppets."

"I'll accompany you," Ning Fuyi immediately said.

Liu Wenzhu crouched on the ground looking up at her, extending her delicate hand toward her just like many, many years ago when they agreed to skip practice together, showing a smile.

"Thank you, Yiyi."

"Don't mention it." Ning Fuyi reached out to pull her up.

Footnotes:

1. **Cangyun (苍云)** - Literally "blue/gray clouds"; the name of an ancient kingdom that was apparently destroyed by the demon race
2. **Qiu (秋)** - Referring to Chu Qingqiu, using just part of her name
3. **Jiuying (九婴)** - A mythical creature from Chinese legend, typically depicted as a nine-headed monster
4. **Penglai (蓬莱)** - A legendary mountain from Chinese mythology, often associated with immortals; in this story it appears to be a hostile sect or realm